Four hidden states with full Hankel rank three

Disproof of Conjecture 00000009634

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Abstract

An explicit stationary four-symbol Markov process has full, infinite word-Hankel rank three, but every nonnegative hidden Markov realization needs at least four hidden states. Its positive-probability language has a concrete finite labelled graph presentation, hence is sofic. This disproves the first equality asserted in the conjecture. All-word matrix rank and the obstruction against arbitrary finite hidden-state models are proved in Lean; neither is replaced by a finite numerical rank experiment.

A stationary process on a sofic support

Let the state set and observation alphabet both be $\{0,1,2,3\}$. Put

$$P = \frac{1}{2}\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \pi = (1/4, 1/4, 1/4, 1/4).$$

Observe the state itself. Every row and column of P sums to one, and $\pi P = \pi$. In transition-emission notation set

$$(T_a)_{ij} = P_{ij}\mathbf{1}_{j=a}, \qquad p(w) = \pi T_{w_1} \cdots T_{w_\ell}\mathbf{1}, \qquad p(\varnothing) = 1.$$

This is an ordinary state-emission HMM with deterministic emission $E_j(a) = \mathbf{1}_{j=a}$, observed after each transition. Stationarity makes this timing equivalent to observing the current state.

For a nonempty word,

$$p(a_1 \cdots a_\ell) = \frac{1}{4}\prod_{r=1}^{\ell-1} P_{a_r a_{r+1}}.$$

These are genuine nonnegative cylinder probabilities. Lean proves empty-word normalization and both consistency equations $\sum_a p(aw) = p(w) = \sum_a p(wa)$ for all words.

The word has positive probability exactly when every successive symbol stays fixed or advances by one modulo four. Thus its language is presented by the actual four-vertex directed graph with edges $i \to i$ and $i \to i+1$, labelling vertex i by i. Every vertex has a self-loop, so every finite allowed path extends in both directions. This is a finite labelled presentation of the support; indeed, it is already a shift of finite type.

The whole infinite Hankel rank is three

Index both rows and columns by *all* finite words, including the empty word, and define

$$H_{u,v} = p(uv).$$

Write $r(u) = \pi T_u$ and $f(v) = T_v \mathbf{1}$. Actual word concatenation gives $H_{u,v} = r(u)f(v)$.

The rows of P satisfy $P_{3a} = P_{0a} - P_{1a} + P_{2a}$ for each symbol a. Since

$$f_i(\varnothing) = 1, \qquad f_i(av) = P_{ia} f_a(v),$$

the future vectors satisfy, for every word v,

$$f_3(v) = f_0(v) - f_1(v) + f_2(v).$$

For the empty word this is simply $1 = 1 - 1 + 1$. It follows that the *entire* matrix factors as

$$H_{u,v} = (r_0(u) + r_3(u))f_0(v) + (r_1(u) - r_3(u))f_1(v) + (r_2(u) + r_3(u))f_2(v).$$

Every actual column of H belongs to the span of the same three real columns. Its column-space dimension is therefore at most three. This is a genuine all-word factorization, not an assertion about the transition matrix's rank or a bounded word-length truncation.

For rows $[0], [1], [2]$ and columns $[0], [1], [2]$, the actual Hankel submatrix is

$$\frac{1}{8}\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \det = \frac{1}{512} \neq 0.$$

It has rank three, giving the matching lower bound on the full matrix. Hence

$$\operatorname{rank} H = 3.$$

Lean uses Mathlib's actual infinite-matrix `Matrix.cRank`, the cardinal dimension of the real column span. It proves the upper span inclusion and applies the submatrix-rank inequality for the lower bound. The result is exactly 3 as a cardinal, whose natural-number value is also three.

Subtraction is allowed in this ordinary real linear factorization. That fact is decisive: the factorization does not supply nonnegative hidden-state probabilities.

Every hidden Markov realization needs four states

Consider an arbitrary n-state nonnegative HMM with initial row vector μ and symbol-transition matrices S_a. Their entries are nonnegative, $\sum_s \mu_s = 1$, and $\sum_a \sum_t (S_a)_{st} = 1$ for each state s. Its probabilities are $\mu S_w \mathbf{1}$ for all words. This class includes arbitrary ordinary state-emission HMMs by setting $(S_a)_{st} = E_s(a)Q_{st}$, emitting before the transition. The final transition sums to one, so this gives their ordinary word probabilities for any initial distribution. The concrete stationary witness above uses the equivalent after-transition timing. Allowing general symbol-transition matrices only strengthens the lower bound.

Suppose the model reproduces every $p(w)$. Its length-one versus length-one Hankel block has a nonnegative factorization

$$H_{[i],[j]} = \sum_{s=1}^{n} A_{is} B_{sj}, \qquad A_{is} = (\mu S_i)_s \geq 0, \quad B_{sj} = (S_j \mathbf{1})_s \geq 0.$$

The actual observed block is $P/4$. Its four diagonal entries are positive, and, for every $i \neq j$,

$$H_{[i],[j]} H_{[j],[i]} = 0.$$

For each i, positivity of its diagonal sum supplies a state s_i with $A_{is_i} B_{s_i i} > 0$. Both factors are positive. If $s_i = s_j$ for $i \neq j$, the same two diagonal witnesses force

$$A_{is_i} B_{s_i j} > 0, \qquad A_{js_j} B_{s_j i} > 0.$$

Each product is bounded above by its corresponding nonnegative Hankel sum. Both crossed entries would therefore be positive, contradicting their zero product. Thus $i \mapsto s_i$ is injective and $n \geq 4$.

The original process already gives a four-state HMM. Its minimal hidden-state count is consequently exactly four. The argument permits any competing transition matrices, emission mechanism and initial distribution; it does not assume that a competing realization shares the displayed transition graph or deterministic observations.

Theorem 1. *There exists a stationary output process with finite labelled-graph support whose full infinite Hankel rank is three and whose minimal hidden-state count is four.*

Proof. The process above has finite labelled support and Hankel rank three. The nonnegative-factorization argument bounds every realization below by four states, and the displayed four-state realization attains that bound. □

Scope and formal reproducibility

The first conjunct of the conjecture equates minimal hidden state count with Hankel rank. The displayed $4 \neq 3$ disproves it, and therefore disproves the conjunction. No result concerning finite-word learning complexity or the geometric-isolation assertion is needed or claimed. The standard distinction between general linear quasi-realizations and genuine nonnegative HMM realizations is discussed in [2, Sections 1–2]; the complete counterexample and proof needed here are given above.

The Lean structure `HMM n` imposes the actual initial and symbol-transition nonnegativity and normalization conditions. Its word probability is an actual matrix product, and `Realizes` requires agreement on every finite word. The proof gives both the exact full Hankel rank and an actual least hidden-state count, rather than a bound for one particular presentation.

The all-word rank theorem is `whole_hankel_rank`.

The minimality theorem is named `minimal_hidden_state_count`.

Separate theorems prove both stationary consistency identities, the deterministic-emission bridge and positive probability exactly on paths in the explicit finite labelled graph. The final theorem directly excludes a realization with the Hankel-rank number of states.

Lean 4.19.0 and Mathlib revision
`c44e0c8ee63ca166450922a373c7409c5d26b00b` are pinned. From `lean/`, run

```
lake exe cache get
lake build
lake env lean -DwarningAsError=true Main.lean
```

The complete project is rebuilt afresh and checked with warnings treated as errors. Printed theorem dependencies contain only standard foundational axioms. There are no proof placeholders, custom axioms or untrusted computation oracles.

The supplementary `verify.py` checks exact rational probabilities through length six, support paths, an 85×85 factorization sample and the finite rank certificates. Run `python verify.py` and `tectonic main.tex`. This finite check is not trusted by the all-word Lean proof.

Exact source, provenance, actual build logs and artifact checks are included. The author agent and parent performed separate internal reviews; no external review is claimed.

References

[1] The Last Math Competition, Conjecture 00000009634. Exact bilingual source and provenance included.

[2] Y. Ohta, *On the Realization of Hidden Markov Models and Tensor Decomposition* (2020), arXiv:2008.11487.